But he was in two minds: whether to go or not. He was in charge of NELCO and did not want to leave it before he put it back on the rails again. If he had left, many might even have perceived him as an escapist. He winced at the thought. He, therefore, waited for NELCO's prospects to determinedly turn for the better.

There was another strong influence that held him back. His grandmother had impressed upon him the values that the Tatas were sworn to uphold. As Ratan had said, his 'belief in the Tatas' was shaped by Lady Tata. As he was too committed to the philosophical foundations of the group, he was reluctant to work with any other company.

While Ratan was engaged in reviving NELCO, he landed yet another difficult assignment. This would eventually become a millstone around his neck. It was actually a mill—the Central India Spinning, Weaving and Manufacturing Company Limited (CIM) or Empress Mills as it was known. It had been established in 1877 and was the first enterprise that Jamsetji Tata had set up. It was once the pride of the Tata Group and was famous as the largest industrial establishment in central India.

When Ratan took charge of the enterprise, he stepped into quicksand. 'It was neglected and not well managed … Tata Sons had ignored it,' says Soonawala. 'To his dismay he [Ratan] discovered that Empress Mills were competing not just with other companies but with other mills in the Tata fold who were undercutting it in the marketplace,' wrote a newspaper. The company was facing imminent closure.

In 1976, JRD held a meeting with Naval Tata and Ratan to revive the struggling mill. During the meeting, Ratan was requested to study the short-term and long-term steps required to revive the enterprise. A few weeks later, he sent his recommendations to JRD.

His study underlined two basic approaches for salvaging the mill. The first was a 'holding operation' aimed at arresting the losses. The second was a more elaborate 'remedial plan'. Ratan concluded that both legs of the strategy would require the infusion of funds. He also added that implementation of such a 'finite plan would similarly yield significant results'. But during one of his visits to the mill in January 1977, he realized that its staff was leaving the sinking enterprise.

Before the second week of February was over, Ratan sent another report on the mill's grave situation to JRD, underlining the severe fund crunch that